MONTHLY UPDATE

Egypt: monthly update, September – October 2026

Edition of 2026-10-12 · compiled by Claude Opus from the documents in the Corpus repository

Developments summarised from sources published between the beginning of last month and today.

SUMMARY OF THE MONTH · GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · GEOPOLITICS

Summary of the month

Regulators set Egypt's first age-based rule for children on social platforms: a joint decision reported on 17 September bars accounts for children under 13 and makes a safe mode the child cannot disable compulsory for those aged 13 to under 15, and the telecoms regulator says a platform that does not comply within three months can be blocked in Egypt. The regulator referred all four mobile operators to the Public Prosecution over lines registered without their subscribers' consent, the central bank approved the rules governing the national digital financial identity, and on 18 September the communications and interior ministries opened a biometric verification and e-signature platform to licensed mobile operators.

Huawei bid to build the government's artificial-intelligence data centres against a rival consortium the US State Department is assembling, Vodafone Business and Cassava Technologies announced a sovereign AI data centre on 8 September, and the communications minister said a national data-centre strategy will be launched by the end of 2026. The justice ministry's E-Court platform went live on 31 August with lawyers' fees the Lawyers Syndicate calls unconstitutional.

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

The communications minister said on 22 September that a national data-centre strategy would be launched by the end of 2026, having told a cabinet meeting on 20 September that it is being drawn up with other ministries to expand data-centre capacity inside Egypt; no draft text is held. On 9 September he put the Digital Egypt platform at about 245 live services, with more than 400 targeted by 2030, against the over 270 by end-2026 and about 450 by 2030 he set out in July.

Legislation and regulation

The telecoms regulator said on 18 September that it is preparing a comprehensive digital-safety law with the House of Representatives' ICT committee, to sit beside the joint decision on children's accounts; no draft is published.

The Financial Regulatory Authority's Decision No. 2735 of 2026 gives consumer and small-business finance companies two months to verify customers by one-time password, and a protocol signed on 16 September requires the media council to take the authority's technical opinion, within fifteen days, before licensing any app that carries on non-bank financial activity or uses a supervised firm's name. On 1 September two more fintech projects received preliminary approval to enter the authority's sandbox.

The ministry's investment conference on 7 September carried a session on the data-protection executive regulations alongside ICT investment, artificial intelligence and startup finance, seven weeks before the compliance period closes on 1 November. No guidance, decision or transfer licence issued under the regulations is on the record. The House ICT committee's newly elected chair said the digital-safety bill heads the committee's agenda for the new session and mostly regulates children's use of social media; no text is published. The chair of the House communications committee said the new session would open with the digital safety bill, which gives priority to protecting children on social media.

Data protection

A joint decision of the media council and the telecoms regulator, reported on 17 September, bars social platforms from holding independent accounts for children under 13, makes a safe mode the child cannot disable compulsory for those aged 13 to under 15, and requires age verification that collects no more data than it needs. The regulator says platforms have three months to comply, existing accounts included, and can be blocked in Egypt if they do not, and that tens of thousands subscribed in two months to the operators' child online-protection services. The decision's text is not held.

On 29 September two rights organisations asked the media council and the telecoms regulator to publish the joint decision's full text, number and legal basis, which the 17 September announcement did not carry, and to state what age-verification data will be collected, by whom and for how long. A law firm reported that the data-protection centre opened its portal for accreditation, licence and permit applications in early October 2026, weeks before the grace period ends.

Regional collaboration

The communications ministry took part in the second Arab artificial-intelligence summit at Hammamet from 7 to 10 September, organised by the Arab ICT organisation with the League of Arab States, working towards unified Arab positions on artificial-intelligence governance, digital sovereignty and data protection. No instrument, declaration text or work programme from it is held.

Finance

New investments

Zeal, an Egyptian payments-software company, raised US$10m to take its checkout customer-identification layer for card terminals into the Middle East, Europe and Africa (10 September); no investor is named. Synapse Analytics raised a US$13m Series A led by Partech (14 September).

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

On 7 September the incumbent's agreement with Power Sub Link to construct the 200 km Sharm El Sheikh to Taba cable was reported, extending its Red Sea festoon into a continuous Suez – Zafarana – Ras Ghareb – Sharm El Sheikh – Taba route designed for about 5 petabits per second. Earlier accounts put the contractor as Greek; no cost, landing-station arrangement or in-service date is held either way.

Vodafone Egypt began the commercial rollout of an AI-capable radio-access processor built for 5G-Advanced (21 September), with no site count or value given.

The main exchange, EG-IX, peaked at 722.19Gb/s on 7 September across 18 member networks, only five of them Egyptian; it is owned by the state-controlled incumbent.

Data Storage

On 3 September the communications minister met a US data-centre developer and the American consortium it leads to discuss an integrated hyperscale and AI zone, with no investment figure stated.

Agreements linking Vodafone Business, Cassava Technologies and Elsewedy Electric were put at up to US$1bn (15 September), with no site, capacity or date. A domestic investment holding reviewed its Kemet data centre in the Suez Canal Economic Zone with the communications minister on 23 September: an 80 MW Tier III site with USD 270 million allocated to the first phase of a project put at USD 1.2 billion. No timeline was disclosed. An investment company's chief executive put installed data-centre IT load at about 15 to 20 MW, against 400 to 500 MW announced, of which about 20 MW is committed. The state digital-finance operator signed a memorandum with a Chinese cloud provider to explore offering its services to Egyptian businesses from locally hosted infrastructure.

Energy

A government official said the electricity ministry had approved an EGP 3bn expansion of the El Alamein and Dabaa transformer zones, with two 500 kV substations, to serve data centres.

DPI

Data Exchange

The financial regulator ordered consumer and small-business lenders to report approvals, repayments and legal action to the credit bureau in real time, under decisions 174 and 175 of 2026, and its Decision No. 2863 requires consumer-finance companies to consult the bureau's behavioural score, built on alternative data, from 1 April 2027. The stock exchange and the internal trade authority signed a protocol integrating the commercial registry with exchange databases (20 August), and the environment agency and the export-control body signed one to exchange industrial facilities' environmental data through a unified registry (1 September). The health minister discussed a proposed national platform linking patient records across health facilities (14 September); it is a proposal, with no build stage or date.

The non-bank regulator's Decision 2684 came into force on 24 September, requiring consumer-finance companies to build the technology to link their databases to the regulator's, including real-time purchase data. The controls that set when the data flows are due within six months.

Digital Identity and CRVS

The regulator piloted a remote biometric verification system for telecom services from 26 August, and on 18 September the communications and interior ministries opened a biometric verification and electronic-signature platform that licensed operators can offer inside their own apps, with no branch visit; no user count or list of relying services is stated. Telecom Egypt launched electronic customer identification with e-signature for mobile line sales, and the central bank's board approved the rules governing the national digital financial identity on 23 August.

Digital Payments and Fintech

On 13 August eFinance, which operates the government payments network, agreed the full acquisition of an Egyptian non-bank lender to small and medium firms, and on 20 September its shareholders approved buying 99.32% for EGP 956.37m in cash and a swap of 146.08m new shares. Neither record states any separation between running government payment rails and holding a lending book that runs on them.

The telecom regulator counted 57.01m operator wallets in the first half of 2026, up 23% in a year, with 67% registered to men.

The largest private bank's digital-bank venture, holding preliminary approval, put its planned investment at up to US$300m ahead of a pilot for individual and diaspora customers. The central bank is laying groundwork for a digital pound, wholesale before any retail use, with no pilot, design paper or date published.

Six Egyptian banks have applied to the central bank for final approval to connect InstaPay to the continental payment system, the system's chief executive said in September. InstaPay does not yet carry cross-border transactions, and neither the banks nor a launch date were named. Afreximbank is also connecting the continental card scheme to the national Meeza network (20 September), at an early stage with no availability date.

Registries

The supply ministry's figure of 850,000 people removed from the food-subsidy system since June 2026, with millions more slated for exclusion next year, was reported on 12 September. Under a protocol reported on 3 September, eFinance is to host Rashid, the national platform cataloguing state-owned and state-contributed companies.

The financial regulator surveyed creditors on the Egyptian Movable Collateral Registry's services and electronic system and reviewed the findings with its operator, E-Finance; the proposals go to technical and legal review, and no registration count is published.

Sectoral management information systems

The procurement authority told the prime minister on 2 September that it is building a national medical-stock database and has moved stocktaking onto a mobile scanning application, putting the system at 38,000 health-sector users, 11,000 medical facilities and 2,000 suppliers across the procurement, storage, dispensing and reconciliation cycle, with warehouses standardised by actual operating state and stock balances updating in real time. The figures and the claim that the design meets audit and finance requirements are the authority's own; about EGP 90bn is allocated this financial year for medicines and medical supplies, and no completion date or independent audit of the system is published.

The justice ministry's E-Court platform went live on 31 August for first-instance criminal courts, charging lawyers EGP 500 a year, EGP 500 per remote felony hearing and EGP 10 a page for case-file copies, with EGP 100 for detention renewals. Lawyers asked the Administrative Judiciary Court to annul the fees as not set by statute, and the ministry replied that use is optional and was requested by the bar.

The finance ministry began surveying road-freight companies at land ports to link them to Nafeza, the single window already used for sea and air cargo, with consolidated land bills of lading and pre-arrival cargo data planned. The account rests on unnamed officials, and no timetable is set.

On 23 September the agriculture ministry's spokesman said its digital register of agricultural holdings ties each holding to the crop actually grown across about 4.4 million farmer cards, to target subsidised fertiliser and record encroachment on farmland. No launch date or coverage of all holdings was given. A former chair of the communications ministry's legislation committee reports that the House's legislative committee has proposed deferring the new Criminal Procedure Law by a further year, and ties the deferral to gaps in its provisions on electronic notification and remote hearings; no parliamentary record of the proposal is held.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

The card is issued free as a prepaid, fingerprint-authenticated card through the postal service, carrying bread and ration subsidy alongside health insurance, and usable at point-of-sale terminals and cash machines; no issuance count, coverage figure, governorate list or completion date is published.

The prime minister said on 3 September that faults in the unified electricity platform and discrepancies in prepaid-meter readings are a government priority and that remedial steps will be announced transparently, the question put to him describing the platform as having stopped working. The operator has published no outage notice, fault count or restoration date.

At its UN award shortlisting the services platform reported 12.9 million registered citizens, more than 240 services and about 60 million transactions, integrated with 109 government entities, the ministry's own figures. The prosecution put five personal-status documents - marriage, divorce and acknowledgement records - on its portal on 10 September, behind the national digital identity, and the environment ministry launched IDEIA on 1 September, moving environmental impact assessment applications, review and approval online.

The investment ministry's digital transformation aide described a capital-increase platform linking the eight government bodies involved, from the investment authority to the commercial registry and central depository, with digital-identity log-in, remote signing and e-passport checks on foreign investors on 22 September. No transaction count or go-live date was given.

Key ration card services became available on the Digital Egypt platform: heads of household can update card data, replace or activate cards, transfer a file between governorates and add family members, with the data-update service introduced in Port Said for an initial three months.

Digitalisation

Rural digital data capture

The communications minister told a cabinet meeting on digital projects that the village fibre sits inside the incumbent's national programme to replace copper with fibre optic cable across the country, laying fibre in the villages of the rural development initiative to bring high-speed internet to rural residents. No route length, cost or completion date accompanies the wider programme, and the village and line counts held here are June's.

Technology

AI

On 8 September the communications minister attended a Cairo ceremony at which Vodafone Business, Elsewedy Electric and Cassava Technologies undertook to establish Africa Data Centres Egypt and the country's first sovereign artificial-intelligence data centre, the state framing both as localising advanced technology and hosting and processing data domestically. No site, date or capacity for the AI centre is stated.

The cabinet information centre put those who had heard of artificial-intelligence applications at 65% in 2026 against 22% in 2023, work the leading use at 51.7% ahead of personal use and study, with about 94% of users rating the accuracy of the answers they get. Sample size, method and margin are not stated.

The national AI council adopted the strategy's achievements report for the first half of 2026, reviewed the outlines of a National Quantum Computing Strategy 2027-2030, and covered government procurement guidelines for AI systems, generative-AI guidelines for government and Safe Use Guidelines for AI Applications for Children, reported on 25 September. None of the guidelines is stated as adopted or published. A newspaper reported that Egypt led the Human Rights Council to adopt by consensus a resolution on artificial intelligence and human rights.

ICT Industry

Opening the sixth Tech Invest Egypt conference on 7 September, the communications minister put outsourcing exports at US$5.1bn at end-2025 against a target of US$8bn by 2028, and sector growth at 24.3% in the fourth quarter of 2025/26; on 9 September he put handset production at about 10 million in 2025, from 3 million in 2024.

A US outsourcing firm opened an AI-powered delivery hub in Cairo on 17 September, planning to grow from about 135 staff to 1,365 over three years. An Egyptian enterprise AI company expanded into Bahrain with a local operator (10 September), a Jordanian education platform acquired an Egyptian maker of tutoring-centre software (2 September), price not stated, and a B2B fashion marketplace reported about EGP 40m transacted since launch (10 August).

Innovation ecosystem

The investment and foreign trade ministry said it will launch TradeTech, a regulatory sandbox and innovation hub for foreign-trade technology, in October 2026.

Capacity

Literacy

As the school year opened, the education minister put free tablets at about 700,000 secondary students a year with an extension to technical education, above 1.2 million devices announced in total, a figure set in the same account against connection costs and teacher readiness. No count of devices delivered or in use is published.

The communications ministry signed a three-year memorandum with Intel on 16 September to train one million citizens a year in AI and certify 500 trainers a year; no cost is stated.

Training and skills

The national telecommunication institute signed a memorandum with Cisco to certify 3,000 technology instructors, 1,000 a year for three years (2 September), and protocols on AI capacity building with a state authority, enterprise-systems training with a private firm and digital transformation and automation with another. None publishes a cohort size, cost or placement target.

The presidential Digilians initiative admitted 1,674 of about 40,000 applicants to its first cohort, the state paying EGP 500,000 to EGP 1m per trainee for master's and diploma tracks in AI, data science, software and cybersecurity, on ministry figures; no completion figure is published. The communications and labour ministries signed a memorandum to digitise the labour ministry's work and run digital-skills programmes for its staff, graduates and job seekers.

Research institutions

A peer-reviewed study assessed administrative readiness and institutional capacity for governing artificial-intelligence-driven digital transformation in the public health system, written by authors at Egyptian, Saudi and Jordanian institutions. The repository holds no state readiness assessment of the same question against which to read it.

Inclusion

Access to services

The supply ministry conceded that people struck off the ration-card system cannot obtain the documents an appeal requires, 2,600 appeals having followed about 850,000 deleted cards (2 August). The central bank put financial inclusion at 79% at end-June 2026, 56.4 million people of an eligible 71.4 million, with women at 72.5%. Google raised consumer cloud-storage prices in Egypt, Nigeria and Algeria, from 27 July for new subscribers.

The refugee agency's year-end monitoring of its 2024 multi-purpose cash assistance interviewed 393 of 434 sampled households and found 99% able to buy items they could not previously afford. It is a self-evaluation on a sample rather than the caseload, and it reports purchasing ability rather than any wider outcome.

Digital divides

The transport ministry added text-to-speech, sign-language and other accessibility tools to its website, built with the ICT ministry and its academy for persons with disabilities (17 September), after the ICT ministry published an accessibility toolbar on every page of its own site on 4 August. No deadline, list of bound entities, conformance level or audit route is stated.

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

The prime minister witnessed the signing of a letter of intent between the communications ministry and Cisco Systems on 1 September, on scaling artificial intelligence across government and priority sectors. The letter carries no value, scope of works or deadline, unlike the Mediterranean capacity partnership already on the ledger.

China activities

During the Chinese president's September visit the communications minister signed a memorandum on technological and digital cooperation covering cloud computing, data centres, semiconductors and cybersecurity. The text is not held, and no project, value or timetable is attached to it.

Gulf/UAE activities

On 21 September Abu Dhabi's sovereign investor co-led a US$35m pre-Series C round in an Egyptian-founded payments company. It is the only Gulf commitment in the window; no Saudi or Qatari commitment is held.

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